

NO PRIOR AUTHORIZATION

Microblading & PMU *Playbook*

THE COMPLETE PMU BUSINESS SYSTEM

6 Modules • 80+ Pages

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MICROBLADING & PERMANENT MAKEUP PLAYBOOK

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The PMU Artist's Playbook

CLIENT SCREENING · BROW MAPPING · HEALING TIMELINES · COLOR THEORY · RETENTION SYSTEMS

1

The PMU Consultation

The healing process conversation is everything — this is where retention is won or lost

OPENING SCRIPT — EVERY CONSULTATION

"Before we talk about what we're going to create, I want to walk you through the entire process — especially the healing. Because honestly, the healing phase is where most people get surprised, and I don't want you to be surprised. I want you to know exactly what to expect so that when day 5 comes and your brows look patchy, you remember that I told you that was going to happen — and you trust the process."

This single opening prevents the majority of negative reviews in PMU. Clients who are surprised by the healing process blame the artist. Clients who were prepared for it trust the artist. Set the expectation before you pick up a tool.

Contraindication screening — who cannot be treated

ABSOLUTE CONTRAINDICATIONS — DO NOT PROCEED

- Pregnancy or breastfeeding — pigment absorption risk, pain medication limitations
- Active skin conditions in treatment area: eczema, psoriasis, dermatitis, active acne
- Keloid scarring history — high risk of raised, thick scar tissue in brow area
- Blood thinners or anticoagulants — uncontrolled bleeding compromises pigment retention
- Isotretinoin (Accutane) use within 12 months — skin cell turnover too rapid, pigment won't retain
- Chemotherapy — immune-compromised skin; defer until cleared by oncologist
- Hemophilia or bleeding disorders — cannot control blood flow during procedure

PROCEED WITH CAUTION — DOCUMENT AND ADJUST

- Diabetes — healing is slower; pigment retention may be poor; physician clearance recommended
- Thyroid conditions — can affect pigment color shift over time
- Oily skin — strokes may heal softer and powdery; discuss powder brow or combo instead
- Previous permanent makeup — assess existing pigment, color, depth before adding new work

- Recent Botox in brow area — wait 2 weeks before mapping; brow position is altered

The style consultation — nail this before you map

STYLE CONSULTATION SCRIPT

"I want to show you a few different brow styles — from very natural, hair-stroke brows to a more defined, fuller look. I also want to see the brows you love and the ones that make you say 'not for me.' Can you show me a few inspo photos on your phone? And then I'll show you what I think would work beautifully with your face shape."

Always see their inspo photos before you design anything. A client's idea of "natural" and your idea of "natural" may be completely different. Inspo photos eliminate guesswork and protect you from misaligned expectations.

2–3 hr

Initial appointment time

6–8 wk

Touch-up window

12–18 mo

Average retention period

2

Brow Mapping & Design

Symmetry is not sameness — faces are not symmetric and neither are perfect brows

WHAT TO SAY BEFORE YOU MAP

"I'm going to map your brows now — I'll mark everything out and show you before I do anything permanent. We'll look at it together, make any adjustments, and when you love what you see, then we start. You're in complete control of this step."

Client approval of the mapping is not optional. Show them in a handheld mirror before you begin. Take a photo with your device. Document their verbal approval in your chart. This protects you.

The golden ratio mapping method

1

Head: straight up from the alar base

The brow head begins directly above the outer edge of the nostril. Mark both sides. Assess symmetry — if asymmetric, note which eye sits higher or which brow naturally sits further in.

2

Arch: above the outer limbus of the iris

When looking straight ahead, the arch falls above the outer edge of the iris. The arch height depends on the client's natural brow bone and their desired look — higher arch = more lifted appearance.

3

Tail: from the alar base through the outer canthus

Draw an imaginary line from the outer edge of the nostril through the outer corner of the eye — the tail ends where this line meets the brow plane. The tail should never drop below the head.

4 Map, photograph, adjust, approve

Map in white pencil first. Take a photo in good lighting. Have the client look in the mirror standing up — gravity changes brow position when lying down. Only proceed after explicit verbal approval.

THE SYMMETRY CONVERSATION — SAY THIS EVERY TIME

"I want to show you something — your face, like every face, is naturally asymmetric. Your left eye sits slightly higher than your right. What I'm going to do is create brows that look balanced and beautiful together, not brows that are mathematically identical — because mathematically identical brows on an asymmetric face actually look more uneven. Does that make sense?"

Face shape guide — adjust the design accordingly

FACE SHAPE	BROW RECOMMENDATION	WHAT TO AVOID
Oval	Soft angled arch — nearly any shape works	Overly dramatic arch looks harsh
Round	Higher arch, longer tail — elongates face	Flat, rounded brows amplify roundness
Square	Soft, curved arch — softens strong jaw	Sharp high arches add severity
Heart	Low, soft arch with rounded shape	High arches widen already-wide forehead
Long / oblong	Flat arch, extended tails — adds width	High arches elongate the face further

3

Techniques & Color Theory

The right technique for the right skin type — and color choices that heal beautifully

Technique selection guide

TECHNIQUE	BEST FOR	NOT IDEAL FOR	RETENTION
Microblading Hair-stroke, manual hand tool	Normal to dry skin, sparse brows, natural look	Oily skin, large pores, mature skin	12–18 months
Powder / Ombre Brow Machine shading, soft to defined	All skin types esp. oily, fuller defined look	Clients wanting ultra-natural hair strokes	2–3 years
Combo Brow Microblading front + shading tail	Most clients — best of both techniques	Very oily or very mature skin	15–24 months
Nano Brows Machine hair strokes — finer than blade	Sensitive skin, clients who want strokes but can't microblade	Budget-conscious clients (higher artist skill required)	18–24 months

Color theory — the healed result is what matters, not the fresh result

THE MOST IMPORTANT COLOR TRUTH IN PMU

The color you place is not the color they'll have in 6 weeks. Every pigment shifts during healing. Iron oxide pigments can shift warm (orange, red) or cool (grey, blue) depending on skin undertone, depth of implantation, and the client's metabolism. Always select color for the healed result — not the fresh application.

COLOR SELECTION BY SKIN UNDERTONE

- **Cool/pink undertone:** use a slightly warm pigment to counteract — cool pigment on cool skin heals ashy and gray
- **Warm/yellow undertone:** use a slightly cool or neutral pigment — warm pigment on warm skin heals orange
- **Olive undertone:** neutral-warm pigments work best — avoid anything with red base
- **Deep/dark skin:** cooler pigments heal more true — warm pigments can look muddy on deeper skin tones
- **Mature skin:** go slightly lighter than target color — pigment appears more saturated in thinner skin

THE COLOR CONVERSATION WITH THE CLIENT

"The color I put on today is going to look darker and more intense than your healed result — that's completely normal and expected. Over the next 4 weeks, it's going to lighten by about 30–40%. I'm choosing a color that's going to heal to the shade you love — not necessarily the shade that looks perfect right now fresh off the table. So if you look in the mirror today and think 'that's too dark' — hold that thought for 6 weeks."

4

The Healing Timeline

What actually happens day by day — and exactly what to tell your client

THE HEALING EDUCATION SCRIPT — DAY OF APPOINTMENT

"I'm going to walk you through what the next 6 weeks look like because this is the part most artists don't prepare their clients for — and it's the part that causes the most panic. Write this down or screenshot my aftercare card: Days 1–3, they'll look dark and bold. Days 4–7, they'll start to flake and peel — do not pick. Days 8–14, they'll look patchy and too light, maybe even like they're disappearing. That is completely normal — it's called the ghost phase. By week 6, the color resurfaces and settles. Week 8 is when we reassess and do your touch-up. Do you have any questions before I let you go?"

The ghost phase is the #1 cause of panic calls and negative reviews. A client who knows it's coming trusts you through it. A client who wasn't warned thinks you did a bad job.

Day-by-day healing reference

● Days 1–3: Dark and bold

Brows appear 30–50% darker than final result. Slight swelling and redness normal. Some lymph fluid weeping is normal — blot gently, do not wipe. Client may be self-conscious — reassure them this is temporary.

Normal healing

● Days 4–7: Flaking and peeling

Skin begins shedding — this is the outer layer of skin releasing, not the pigment. Do NOT pick, scratch, or peel. Picking removes pigment with the flaking skin and causes patchy results and scarring.

Critical phase — no picking

● Days 8–21: The ghost phase

Brows appear light, patchy, or nearly invisible. Pigment is present — it is temporarily hidden under a layer of new skin forming over the treated area. This is the phase that causes the most concern. Every client needs to know it's coming.

Ghost phase — totally normal

● Weeks 4–6: Color resurfaces

Pigment gradually resurfaces as the new skin thins and becomes translucent. Color will appear softer and more natural than the initial application. This is the result beginning to show.

Results emerging

● Week 6–8: Healed result — touch-up assessment

True healed result is visible. Assess: pigment retention, symmetry, color accuracy, stroke definition. This is when the touch-up appointment happens — not before.

Touch-up window

Aftercare instructions — given in writing

DAYS 1–14: THE NON-NEGOTIABLES

- Blot lymph fluid with clean tissue — do not rub or wipe
- Apply thin layer of aftercare ointment (Aquaphor or provided balm) 2–3x daily
- Do not get brows wet for 7–10 days — no swimming, steam, excessive sweating
- Do not apply makeup over brow area until fully healed
- No sun exposure on brows — UV fades pigment and inflames healing skin
- Do not pick, scratch, peel, or rub — this is the most important rule
- Sleep on a clean pillowcase — preferably satin to reduce friction

5

The Touch-Up System — Your Retention Engine

Every PMU client needs a touch-up. The ones who come back become your most loyal clients.

THE #1 RETENTION MISTAKE — NOT BUILDING THE TOUCH-UP INTO THE ORIGINAL SALE

Artists who sell a single session and "offer" a touch-up as an add-on lose clients after appointment one. Artists who sell a two-session package as the standard experience retain nearly every client into annual refreshes. The touch-up is not optional — it is part of the process. Price accordingly and present it that way from day one.

Touch-up pricing and positioning

HOW TO STRUCTURE THE TWO-SESSION MODEL

- **Initial session:** Full price (\$400–\$700 depending on market and technique)
- **Perfecting touch-up (6–8 wks):** Included in initial price OR \$75–\$150 add-on clearly stated at booking
- **Annual refresh (12–18 months):** 50–60% of initial price — brows are partially faded, less work than starting fresh
- **Color boost (6–12 months):** \$150–\$250 — pigment refresh without full rework

HOW TO PRESENT THE TWO-SESSION MODEL AT BOOKING

"I want you to know upfront that microblading is always a two-session process. The first session is where we build the foundation and the second session — which we schedule 6 to 8 weeks later — is where we perfect it. After your brows heal and we can see exactly how your skin took the pigment, that's when I fine-tune everything. The two sessions together are what give you the finished result. So when you book today, we'll go ahead and get both appointments on the calendar."

Book the touch-up at the initial appointment — before they leave. Clients who leave without a touch-up appointment booked have a 40–50% lower show rate for that follow-up.

The touch-up assessment — what to evaluate at 6–8 weeks

- 1 Pigment retention mapping**
Which areas retained well? Which faded? Areas with poor retention indicate shallow implantation or oily skin in that zone — adjust depth or technique for the touch-up.
- 2 Color accuracy**
Has the color shifted warm, cool, or healed true? Assess against the target and adjust pigment selection for the touch-up session accordingly.
- 3 Symmetry check**
Compare to before photos. Any asymmetry that emerged during healing? Fill gaps, add definition where needed, correct any strokes that healed with unwanted softness.
- 4 Client satisfaction check**
"How do you feel about them?" before you assess. Their answer shapes what you fix. A client who says "I love them but wish the arch was a tiny bit higher" gives you a very different job than one who says "they look great."

ANNUAL REFRESH – THE REBOOKING SCRIPT

"Your brows are going to stay beautiful for another 6 to 12 months — and then you'll start to notice the color softening and some strokes fading. When that happens, it's time for your annual refresh. I'll have my team reach out to you around the 12-month mark to get you on the calendar before they fade too much. Does that sound good?" Set the expectation now. The 12-month outreach then feels like care, not a sales call.

6

PMU Menu & Revenue Strategy

Building a full PMU service menu that serves clients at every stage

Full PMU service menu

SERVICE	TECHNIQUE	TIME	PRICE RANGE
Microblading Includes perfecting touch-up	Manual blade	2.5–3 hrs	\$450–\$700
Powder / Ombre Brows Machine — longer lasting	Machine shading	2–2.5 hrs	\$400–\$650
Combination Brows Most popular service	Blade + machine	3–3.5 hrs	\$500–\$750
Nano Brows Machine hair strokes	Machine	2.5–3 hrs	\$500–\$800
Lip Blush Natural wash of color	Machine	2.5–3 hrs	\$450–\$700
Eyeliner PMU Lash line enhancement	Machine	2–2.5 hrs	\$350–\$550
Annual Refresh Returning clients only	Match original	1.5–2 hrs	\$200–\$350

Revenue model — PMU as a predictable income stream

THE MATH ON A FULL PMU BOOK

At 3 new microblading clients per week at \$550 average = \$1,650/week in new client revenue. Plus annual refreshes: 50 returning clients per year at \$275 average = \$13,750 in annual refresh revenue. A fully booked PMU artist doing combo brows 4 days per week generates \$85,000–\$120,000+ annually before any add-on services. The key is retention — every new client is a recurring annual revenue stream if you build the relationship correctly.

Upsell and cross-sell for PMU clients

NATURAL SERVICE ADD-ONS

- Lash lift + tint — same visit or separate — PMU clients are already comfort with permanent enhancement
- Brow lamination — for clients not ready for PMU yet; keeps them in your chair
- Skincare consult — post-PMU skin prep and SPF retail is a natural conversation
- Lip blush after brow microblading — they already trust you; the upsell is organic
- Referral program — "Send a friend, get \$50 off your next refresh"

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